

transfer rate of the network, measured as the number of bits per second (known as the “throughput”) is the same, and, as mentioned earlier, the telephone line would remain occupied as long as you continue to access the Net.

1.1.4 Choosing An Internet Service Provider

Perhaps the most dicey part of accessing the Internet is finding the right ISP. The first decision you need to make is whether to go with a dialup ISP or a broadband ISP such as a DSL provider or satellite or cable Internet service. We thought it would help if you could have an overview of the differences between dialup and broadband services, and so, here’s a table:

Whichever you opt for, when you’re choosing an ISP there are few fundamentals you should consider:

1. **Local phone number:** ISPs typically need you to dial a number that your computer must contact to connect to the Internet. If this number is not local but a long-distance one, you could spend a lot more than you intend to.
2. **Cost:** Costs that you will incur in using an ISP’s services vary from one provider to another, and is usually the factor that will most influence your choice. Each ISP gives a certain number of hours per month which you can use. Charges differ according to the kinds of service you need and the quantum of data you give or receive. Off-peak hours are sometimes free, while extra charges are applied for every extra hour (or MB) you use. Some ISPs charge a one-time fee for setup and then a monthly rental. We advise you to first determine the kind of usage you have in mind. If you are an occasional user and don’t think you’ll need the Net much, just settle for good old dialup. But if you need to send or receive a lot of data, you could choose from the variety of schemes that are offered by ISPs that let you connect through cable or DSL.
3. **Mailboxes:** ISPs often allow you to have multiple e-mail addresses for your Internet account. This is sometimes free and can be availed of.